

Ayoung Kim. *Many Worlds Over*

Ayoung Kim (b. 1979 in Seoul, South Korea) builds worlds that exist between fiction and reality. Using tools such as Artificial Intelligence (AI) and computer-generated imagery (CGI), as well as architectural and sculptural elements, she creates highly immersive environments. For her exhibition at Hamburger Bahnhof, Kim pulls together components from a cycle of works that follows the story of a female delivery driver and her identical double. Two video installations, wallpapers, sculptures, and a computer game tell a story set in a fictional, futuristic Seoul. To create this universe, Kim uses speculative fiction, a literary genre that imagines worlds, futures, or realities different from our own. *Many Worlds Over* extends Kim's universe into the exhibition space. Mirrored walls and metal structures disrupt the layout of the gallery. The viewers' sense of time and space is altered as they unexpectedly encounter their own reflections and those of others at different moments in the exhibition.

Delivery Dancer's Sphere, 2022

The video *Delivery Dancer's Sphere* is the first in Kim's *Delivery Dancer* work cycle. It introduces Ernst Mo, a female delivery driver who navigates a fictionalised version of a futuristic Seoul. Riding her motorbike, she accepts orders through an app on her phone that is controlled by an Artificial Intelligence (AI) called Dancemaster. At times, the app loses track of Ernst Mo. She has not vanished but exists in two places at once. In these moments, she encounters her identical double from a parallel world: En Storm. Ernst Mo and En Storm's names are both a rearrangement of the word monster, reflecting the bizarre nature of their encounters. Their repeated meetings, marked by both attraction and resentment, open portals to new timelines and worlds.

Single-channel video installation, 25 mins.

Courtesy the artist and Gallery Hyundai

Ghost Dancers B, 2022

The two mannequins in this gallery represent Ernst Mo and En Storm, Kim's protagonists from the *Delivery Dancer* videos, which are on view in this exhibition. While the mannequins are dressed in the same rider outfits and helmets as the characters in the films, their faces remain hidden behind visors displaying blue LED masks. One woman leans over the other who struggles to rise from the ground scattered with broken glass. With no facial expressions visible, their body language opens up the possibility of reading their interaction in different ways. On screen, the women's bodies are in constant motion, but as sculptures, they are frozen in time. The viewer's body, rendered still while watching the video, is now the one that moves.

Mannequins, costumes, helmets, LED masks, wigs, gloves, reinforced cases, tempered glass

Courtesy the artist and Gallery Hyundai

Orbit Dance series, 2022

The Orbit Dance series consists of six sculptures scattered throughout the exhibition space. In three of them, entangled metal structures extend from the surface of round mirrors. In the other three, similar metal structures hang like mobiles from the ceiling. Kim based the form of these works on the Alexander horned sphere, a specific example of a strange shape in topology, a branch of mathematics that studies shapes and spaces. Kim uses this shape to give physical form to the complex relationships between the characters, times, and places in her worlds. The sculptures in this series reflect the universes in Kim's videos, where time is not linear but rather cyclical.

Brass, nickel

Courtesy the artist and Gallery Hyundai

Ghost Dancers A, 2022

Two motorcycle helmets are suspended from the ceiling of the gallery, facing each other. They hang at the full body height of the crouching mannequins in the adjacent room. The helmets are drawn from the world that Kim portrays in the two videos on display in this exhibition. Deprived of their bodies, they float in the air with dangling corrugated tubes and wires evoking spinal cords and intestines. Their visors display looping sequences of endless routes, similar to those navigated by the riders in the videos. These routes are created using a game engine, a type of software used to create video games.

Helmets, video, tablets, wire, corrugated tube, metal chain, 3 mins.

Courtesy the artist and Gallery Hyundai

Stipulation, 2022

A phone juts into the exhibition space, mounted at a height that suggests it is ready to be picked up by the viewer, giving physical form to another element from Kim's virtual worlds. In these worlds, riders log in, receive delivery calls, and follow routes calculated by the app's algorithm from pickup to destination. The work's title, Stipulation, refers to a legal term used in contracts indicating a condition, demand, or promise. With this title, Kim emphasises the power exerted by the Artificial Intelligence (AI) that controls the app used by the delivery drivers in the videos in this exhibition.

Mobile phone, video, tablet holder, 3 mins.

Courtesy the artist and Gallery Hyundai

Delivery Dancer's Arc: 0° Receiver, 2022

In this second video in the exhibition, the artist continues to tell the story of the female delivery driver and her identical double. The two protagonists attempt to escape a world that is controlled by the Artificial Intelligence (AI) delivery app that they use. In their pursuit, they move across different times and places. To create these worlds, Kim combines computer-generated imagery (CGI), footage with real actors, and game engines, a type of software used to create video games. The blinking lights visible on the back of the screens, along with the reflections on the mirrored walls enhance the spatial experience of these videos.

Three-channel video installation, 30:32 mins.

Commissioned by ACMI

Courtesy the artist and Gallery Hyundai

Delivery Dancer Simulation (Game), 2022

In this room, visitors can play a computer game titled Delivery Dancer Simulation on a large monitor placed on a reflective surface. The game is installed in a way that positions two players facing each other, yet unable to cross to the other side. Their own reflections in the mirrored exhibition architecture blur the boundaries between their physical presence and Kim's virtual universe. Each player navigates the game as the female delivery driver featured in the other videos on display. Throughout the journey, the driver's thoughts are audible, interrupted by whispers and high-pitched app commands. To advance, players must follow a beam of light and collect letters of the alphabet. This game adds another layer to the exhibition, introducing an interactive dimension that deepens the viewer's engagement with Kim's world.

Game simulation, 12 mins.

Commissioned by C/O Berlin Digital Fellowship

Courtesy the artist and Gallery Hyundai

Evening Peak Time Is Back, 2022

Large-scale wallpapers, titled Evening Peak Time Is Back, cover parts of the exhibition space. Created with the webtoon artist known as 1172, they depict the two protagonists from Kim's videos. Webtoons, Korean online comics, are typically viewed on small screens, but Kim has enlarged these images to a superhuman scale. She is especially drawn to the Girls' Love genre, which explores queer romantic relationships between women. Her wallpapers capture the protagonists in intense, confrontational, and passionate encounters.

(feat. 1172 Character Illustration)

Wallpaper installation

Courtesy the artist and Gallery Hyundai